Introduction

The National Outreach Programme (NOP) at LUMS identifies and admits academically strong students from under resourced schools, low income households, and under represented regions across Pakistan. While NOP students are capable and motivated, their entry into an elite private university comes with layered academic, linguistic, cultural, and financial barriers. Co curricular societies at LUMS are central to student development. They shape

• leadership pipelines,
• access to networks and internships,
• campus visibility,
• and professional skills formation.

However, Praxis' ground up research with approximately 40 NOP students across batches, majors, provinces and schooling systems highlights systemic disadvantages that prevent NOP students from entering, progressing, and leading within societies. These disadvantages are not individual shortcomings. They are structural outcomes of:

• unequal schooling preparation,
• unequal exposure to co curricular culture before university,
• classed and linguistic norms in interviews,
• and social networks that determine reputation, presence and promotions.

This policy paper presents student informed, evidence backed reforms that aim to make societies more equitable and meritocratic, not by lowering standards, but by removing structural filters that misidentify privilege as competence.

Existing Mechanisms in Current Societies Framework

The Centralized Societies Constitution already sets out mechanisms on inclusivity, recruitment, governance and oversight that this policy can build on and operationalize. At the level of values and access, the constitution commits societies to:

• core values including inclusivity, respect, integrity, excellence and alignment with the university mission,

• a non discrimination clause requiring that membership be open to all eligible students without discrimination on protected characteristics,
• general eligibility rules that link access to academic and disciplinary standing rather than informal networks.

At the level of recruitment and membership, the constitution requires:

• at least one open and transparent recruitment cycle every academic year with widely advertised calls for applications, clear deadlines and selection criteria,
• the use of declared and objective selection methods such as application reviews, interviews, auditions or portfolios that are aligned with the stated purpose of the society,
• documentation and CCA approval of any additional society specific eligibility criteria to ensure they are reasonable, fair and non discriminatory,
• annual renewal of membership and clear standards for active and inactive status recorded in membership registers maintained by the General Secretary and shared with CCA when needed.

At the level of governance and accountability, the constitution establishes:

• Executive Councils with defined roles for President, Vice President, Treasurer and General Secretary and a clear chain of command,
• accountability of ECs to General Bodies through regular reporting on activities, finances and progress,
• at least one General Body meeting per semester and a formal feedback mechanism through which members can raise concerns,
• the role of faculty patrons as advisers, mediators and signatories on sensitive selections, and the authority of CCA to review annual performance and intervene where necessary.

At the level of conduct, protection and redress, the constitution:

• sets out a code of conduct based on professionalism, respect, ethics and alignment with the Student Code of Conduct,
• explicitly prohibits harassment, discrimination and misuse of authority and describes tiered consequences including warnings, suspension, termination and referral to university disciplinary procedures,

• provides procedures for reporting violations, protecting confidentiality and safeguarding complainants,
• lays out complaint, investigation, removal and appeal mechanisms for EC members and for general members whose membership is terminated, with final oversight resting with CCA and relevant university offices.

At the level of training and policy awareness, the constitution requires:

• mandatory annual training for EC members on harassment, discrimination, discipline and inclusive practice conducted by CCA and OSA,
• dissemination of key policy information to General Bodies every year so that members are aware of their rights, responsibilities and avenues for recourse.

These existing mechanisms provide a formal framework that can be used to embed the proposed reforms on fair recruitment, inclusion, oversight and accountability within society practice, and to justify CCA monitoring where class coded and exclusionary practices persist.

Problem Identification

2.1 Information Gaps at Entry

Many NOP students do not know:

• which societies exist,
• how to prioritize applications,
• or how recruitment cycles work.

Several students reported joining only the societies where they happened to know someone. Many lacked peer networks to guide them. One law major from Chitral shared that she only applied to Amnesty because a friend told her about it and that was the only place where she knew someone, she had no information about other societies. Another student reported that coaches in orientation week did not properly explain how societies work and said “I had no knowledge about the societies and had no friends in first semester who could tell me to apply.” A political science student stated that they did not even know about the central student office or about academic and co curricular support until their third year. This results in self selection out of opportunities before competition even begins.

2.2 Interview Practices Reproduce Classed and Linguistic Inequalities

Participants consistently reported that interviews, not forms, were the primary barrier. Interviews often tested:

• English fluency and accent,
• social polish and confidence,
• familiarity with elite cultural references,
• and subjective "vibe" matching.

Students described being humiliated, mocked, or dismissed for language, dress, or not knowing internal processes of societies. A student from Mardan recalled that LES rejected him because the interview was fully in English and his confidence "completely dropped," while another student from Swabi described how an interviewer in an economics society humiliated him for not knowing society details and said that after that experience he could not break the language barrier in interviews. One participant from Dir Lower explained that when he sat in a competitive interview and observed the environment and conversation, "mujhe bohot zyada difference mehsoos hua," the whole experience of articulation, language and confidence felt alien and intimidating. Focus group participants also observed that in some societies interviews felt like a "vibe check" where background, schooling and hometown mattered more than ability. This reproduces pre existing disadvantages, rather than measuring competence or work ethic.

2.3 Experience Based Hypothetical Questions Penalize NOP Applicants

Many society interviews included "scenario questions" intended to test experience, such as:

• event management hypotheticals,
• marketing or HR simulations,
• crisis scenarios, etc.

However, NOP students repeatedly reported that:

• they lacked prior exposure to formal societies or co curricular work,
• schools offered no training in leadership, event management or HR culture,
• therefore they could not answer high stakes hypothetical questions.

One participant shared that LUMUN and similar societies were perceived as accessible only to those with prior experience and connections, and that this reputation alone discouraged applications from students “like me.” Another student narrated being given a strict marketing scenario in a LUMUN interview, and when he performed it, the interviewer snapped at him, asking “10 bajay aap kis tarah call karte ho kisi ko,” which left him feeling angry, judged and further discouraged from future interviews. In a focus group, a participant described a drama society interview where the panel asked, “If you do not have a shirt on the day of the event, what will you do,” and felt that these subjective hypotheticals were judged on “vibe” rather than genuine capability. Students expressed that such questions served as subtracting criteria that filtered candidates based on privilege based exposure rather than potential.

2.4 Class, Language and Social Signaling Act as Gatekeepers

Students reported being assessed, implicitly and explicitly, on:

- dressing style,
- footwear,
- accent,
- social confidence,
- and perceived class background.

These cues are often misread as indicators of competence, professionalism, or “fit.”

One participant summarised

“Money = presence = recognition.”

Participants repeatedly remarked that “all these things matter, the way you speak, the way you dress, the way you conduct yourself, even your friend circle,” and that appearing in chappal or low brand clothes signals that “the person is from a weak background” and marks them as NOP in the eyes of others. A student from Waziristan shared that societies often looked first at background, schooling and hometown, and that they seemed to want applicants whose “vibe” matched existing members. Another student who had studied abroad observed that when he had an accent outside Pakistan, people appreciated it, but on campus “the stigmas are so strong that one does not even try to join certain groups,” and that even self described progressives often failed to practice inclusion with students from the periphery.

Thus, the criteria used in selection are not neutral, they reflect class coded norms.

2.5 Promotions Based on Visibility, Not Work

Students described a culture where promotions were tied to:

• hangout visibility,
• networking within elite friend circles,
• ability to attend expensive social activities.

Work quality, reliability, and contribution were described as secondary, invisible or ignored. This disproportionately disadvantages NOP students, who often:

• work part time,
• cannot afford outings,
• and are excluded from social networks of influence.

One student explained that in many societies “big societies needed experience, small societies needed us,” and that for large, prestigious platforms there was a mindset that they wanted to maintain a certain image and that NOP members were “just a cog in the machine.” Another participant stated that “most money and energy go into socializing,” that presence is judged by “how much you spend and where you show up,” and concluded that “no one works for the vision, they work for their CV.” Focus group participants similarly linked nepotism to hangout culture, noting that promotions were handed to those who were present in specific lobbies and circles, not to those who quietly did most of the labor.

2.6 Lack of Representation in Leadership Positions

Across interviews, students said they rarely see NOP students in directorates or ECs of major societies.Even when NOP students work substantially, they remain in low visibility roles.This results in:

• invisible labor,
• lack of professional development,
• and reduced campus influence.

A law student who repeatedly applied to a leading consultancy society asked, “You say you are a pioneering consultancy society, show even one person from NOP, FSC background, small cities, whom you selected and groomed.” Another participant observed, “I do not see any NOP student in EC even when they are working too much,” and focus group participants described ECs as made up of people from the same schools who then promote their peers and keep the circle closed. Several students stressed that while societies advertise themselves as inclusive, in practice “ninety percent” of decisions felt based on connections and background rather than merit.

2.7 Fear of Identity Disclosure and Stigma

Students described reluctance to disclose NOP identity because:

• it triggers stereotyping,
• stigma,
• and pity or tokenizing.

Comments like “we pay for them” were reported in multiple interviews. Several participants shared that NOP identity has become a taboo topic on campus and that they feel uncomfortable opening up about it, even with friends. One student described a classmate’s “very strange reaction” when she disclosed that she was NOP, and another said that remarks in class such as “we pay for them” produced deep humiliation and shaped how NOP students saw themselves. Many students reported feeling exposed when using food vouchers and described standing in voucher lines as if “we are doing a crime,” while others said that uniform NOP bags, tagged water bottles and visible voucher scanning made them feel watched and marked out as different. One participant noted that some peers feel so uncomfortable that they walk away without using the voucher when they see a crowd at the counter. Thus, any policy that reveals identity must ensure strict confidentiality, to avoid further otherization.

Policy Recommendations

We propose policies across three spectrums, membership level, directorate level and EC level.

3.1 Membership Reform

3.1.1 Application Changes.

Interviews must assess

• motivation,
• reliability,
• time commitment,
• and willingness to learn.

Interviews must not assess

• accent, polish, dress,
• social circles,
• or familiarity with elite cultural norms.

Many students avoided applying to societies because they felt interviews were intimidating, class coded, and inaccessible, with expectations of confidence and articulation they were never trained for. One participant said that many NOP students have good ideas but “are not able to articulate them properly, so they should be taught those skills.”

3.1.2 Removal of Experience Based Hypothetical Questions

Experience based hypothetical questions (for example event crisis simulation, marketing scenario, HR problem solving) must be removed from membership interviews. These questions must not be used as subtracting criteria or as proof of competence.

NOP students repeatedly reported that their previous schools had no societies, no event management culture, and no communication training. They came to LUMS without exposure to the contexts these questions assume. One student explicitly said that societies prefer applicants who have “some sort of prior experience,” which they never had access to during schooling. Another described feeling disconnected because “there were no extracurriculars in school, maybe that is why I can not participate here as well.”

Therefore, using experience based hypotheticals unfairly rewards privilege based exposure, not potential.

If any scenario must be used, it should assess

• basic reasoning,
• motivation,
• and willingness to learn.

3.1.3 Diversity Targets (Indirect NOP Inclusion)

Societies must set soft diversity benchmarks for membership based on

• province,
• school type,
• and cultural or linguistic background.

Purpose

• Prevent homogeneity and elite clustering.
• Indirectly support NOP inclusion without forcing identity disclosure.

Interview data shows that many NOP students come from under represented schooling systems, public colleges, and smaller towns. Several students stated they lacked knowledge about societies entirely because "there were no extracurriculars in school." Therefore, diversity benchmarks will help structurally correct unequal starting points.

3.1.4 Anti Lobbying Oversight

If societies are repeatedly dominated by narrow school, provincial, or socio economic clusters, and exclude diverse applicants

• CCA may place the society on diversity probation,
• require a corrective plan,
• and freeze promotions or funding in extreme cases.

3.2 Directorate Level Policies

3.2.1 Optional NOP Identification

Directorate forms must include

“Are you an NOP student”

• Optional disclosure
• Confidential access only to EC and CCA
• No public revelation

3.2.2 Additive NOP Co Director Positions

Where a qualified NOP applicant applies

• Create one additive Co Director seat per department.

3.2.3 Directorate Representation Goal (20 to 30 percent)

Target

• 20 to 30 percent NOP representation across directorate roles
• Distributed across departments, not clustered in low power roles.

3.2.4 Directorate Interview Rubric

Assess

• motivation,
• reliability,
• communication (Urdu or English),
• teamwork and professionalism.

Prohibited criteria

• accent,
• fashion or appearance,
• schooling background,
• lack of prior experience,
• elite networks or “presence.”

3.3 EC Level Policies

3.3.1 Neutral Observer

Every EC interview must include a neutral observer from

- Patron office,
- NOP office,
- or CCA.

3.3.2 Standardized EC Selection Rubric

Evaluate based on

- task completion,
- attendance,
- contribution quality,
- 360 degree peer reviews,
- leadership ethics.

No EC appointment without documented performance.

3.3.3 Training and Integrity Pledge

EC interviewers must attend a training session on

- inclusion,
- bias,
- anti nepotism,
- interview discipline.

Interviewers must sign a declaration affirming

- impartiality,
- confidentiality,
- non discrimination.

3.3.4 Affirmative Action Points

NOP applicants may receive

• up to 10 percent weighted score adjustment in EC evaluations.

Purpose

• offset structural disadvantage, not guarantee selection.

3.4 Confidentiality and Anti Stigma Protocols

• NOP status kept confidential.
• No disclosure, jokes, or identity based remarks.
• Violations result in disciplinary action.
• Data deleted post selection.

3.5 Capacity Building and Support Programs

3.5.1 CCA Workshops for Interviewers

CCA must conduct workshops for all society interviewers before recruitment cycles.

Purpose

• Train interviewers in inclusive practice
• Explain class coded barriers
• Standardize interview conduct

Multiple students reported interview intimidation, humiliation, and fear of being judged or laughed at.

3.5.2 Interview Preparation Workshops for Students

CCA must provide interview preparation workshops open to all, but prioritized for NOP students.

Workshops should cover

• communication skills,
• confidence building,
• mock interviews,

• explanation of society structures,
• application strategies.

A student described hesitation due to poor articulation, saying students “should be taught those skills.” Another said they did not join societies because they “had no knowledge about the societies and had no friends in first semester who could tell me to apply.”

3.5.3 Pre Semester Orientation on Societies

The pre semester NOP program must include

• A structured information session on all societies,
• recruitment timelines,
• roles, skill requirements,
• and growth pathways.

One student stated they were unaware of societies entirely until their third year.

CRITIQUE OF EXISTING MECHANISMS

Although the Centralized Societies Constitution outlines values of inclusivity, transparent recruitment and oversight, these mechanisms remain largely procedural and do not address the structural nature of class, language and exposure based inequality. The constitution assumes that fairness will naturally result from rules such as open calls, documented interviews or non discrimination clauses, but it does not provide any operational safeguards against bias in practice, for example how to ensure interviewers do not evaluate accent, confidence or social signalling, how to prevent lobbying or elite clustering, how to monitor subtle exclusion in directorate or EC promotions, or how to hold societies accountable for repeated patterns of homogenous selection. The framework treats inequality as an ethical issue rather than a systemic one and therefore lacks tools for detection, measurement, enforcement or correction. Without mechanisms such as neutral observers, diversity audits, standardized rubrics, documented scoring, or consequences for biased outcomes, the existing

constitutional provisions remain aspirational rather than transformative and cannot realistically counter the structural disadvantages repeatedly described by NOP students.

Conclusion

Student societies at LUMS occupy a central role in building networks, leadership capacity, and professional opportunity. Yet current mechanisms, recruitment practices, interview cultures, promotion criteria, and leadership pipelines, systematically disadvantage NOP students, not due to lack of ability, but due to structural inequalities in exposure, confidence, and social capital. NOP students themselves do not ask for charity. They demand

• fair assessment,
• equitable access to leadership development,
• and recognition that “equal treatment” cannot exist where starting points are fundamentally unequal.

The policies proposed in this paper do not lower standards.
They refine standards to measure what societies claim to value, motivation, commitment, contribution, and leadership potential, rather than inherited privilege signals like accent, dressing, or experience in elite co curricular environments.

Embedding these policies will allow societies at LUMS to become:

• more meritocratic,
• more representative,
• more developmental,
• and more aligned with the university’s equity mission.

And importantly, they reflect the lived realities, insights, and proposed solutions of students who navigate these barriers every day.